next morning, with only three personnel each. This seemed reasonable and I called up the RM and NSA at 2200 hours to share this news. I had hardly put the phone down when Jo rang up once again at 2210 hours. He said that the tanks had started moving up again and were now only about 500 m away. As per my earlier instructions, they had fired a rocket launcher round into the hillside ahead of them as a warning shot but that had failed to deter them. He recommended that the only way to stop them was by opening up with our own medium artillery, which he said was ready and waiting. Artillery duels were a routine feature on the LC with Pakistan. On any given day or night, perhaps hundreds of rounds would get fired as per the authority delegated to the Divisional and Corps Commanders. If the situation warranted, some suspicious movement or even to counter Pakistani artillery fire, they were free to open up without having to ask anyone up the chain of command. But this was a totally different ball game. My position was critical, caught between the Command who wanted to open fire with all possible means and the CCS, which had yet to give me clear-cut executive orders. Moreover, time was running out.

I conveyed the criticality of the situation to the RM, who said he would get back to me, which he did, by about 2230 hours. He said that he had spoken to the PM and that it was purely a military decision. '*Jo ucchit samjho woh karo*' (Do whatever you deem is appropriate). I had been handed a hot potato. With this carte blanche, the onus was now totally on me. I took a deep breath and sat silently for a few minutes. All was quiet save for the ticking of the wall clock. I was in my den at Army House, with the map of J & K and Ladakh on one wall, Eastern Command on another. They were unmarked maps, but as I looked at them, I could visualize the location of each and every unit and formation. We were ready in all respects, but did I

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